TRANSPORT

Toxicity in Motion

First, we need to have fewer vehicles on the roads. For that you need a fast, efficient mass transport system. Clean fuels should be next

a vehicle should emit at least 80 per cent less particulate matter for every kilometre it travels. The sulphur content in fuel dropped fivefold—from 50 parts per million (ppm) to 10 ppm. NO_2 fumes from diesel cars dropped by 70 per cent and by 5 per cent in petrol cars. From April 1, 2023, automakers have switched to a more stringent version, the BS-VI Phase 2. The Bureau of Energy Efficiency also monitors energy efficiency or CO_2 emissions. Onboard diagnostic systems for vehicles to monitor pollution have been made compulsory, besides selective catalytic reduction systems and particulate filters for exhausts.

Of course, all these measures have pushed up the cost of vehicles, especially of cars. "Stringent emission norms will add to the cost of vehicles, and will hit the entry level segment the hardest," says Gaurav Vaangal, principal analyst with S&P Global. Industry sources estimate the cost impact of the changeover from BS-IV to BS-VI to be in the range of Rs 20,000-Rs 40,000 for petrol cars and even higher for diesel cars. And, if sources are to be believed, the road ministry has begun preparatory work to introduce BS-VII standards, so that India does not lose the momentum on getting less polluting vehicles on its roads that are in step with the global standards of emission. BS-VII will be equivalent to the new Euro 7 norms the European Commission introduced last year.

Meanwhile, the Supreme Court banned diesel vehicles that were 10 years old and petrol ones that were over 15 years old from plying on Delhi's roads and mandated that they be scrapped. In 2021, the Centre had also mandated the same for all commercial vehicles more than 15 years old and passenger vehicles more than 20 years old. Together, they are expected to take more than 5 million vehicles off the roads. However, implementation of stricter vehicular pollution norms is in the hands of states. And how lax things are is evident in the 'Pollution under Control' (PUC) checks on the ground in some states even though the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has asked general insurers not to issue insurance to vehicles without a valid PUC certificate.

Incentivising the use of electric vehicles or EVs is the other significant initiative that the government is pushing to reduce vehicular pollution.

SOLUTIONS

- **After BS-VI, the road transport ministry is preparing BS-VII rules**
- **Promotion of e-vehicles and expansion of charging infrastructure**
- **Promotion of public transport. 10,000 e-buses to be procured for 169 cities under PM ebus Sewa**
- **Vehicle scrapping policy in place; stricter implementation of emission norms needed**
- **Consultations on for a hydrogen fuel framework**



THAT CHOKING FEELING
The Delhi-Gurugram Expressway on a low-visibility day, Nov. 8